“If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need.”

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Where it often comes from

Early experiences of being overlooked can make having to ask feel painful or humiliating. Romantic messages may teach that true love should understand without words. Different family habits, indirect hints, and previous disappointment can lead you to wait silently and then interpret an unmet need as proof of not being loved.

What Scripture teaches

Love includes attention and responsiveness, but it does not give a spouse the ability to read your mind. Pearls encourages listening before answering, timely words, and gentle speech. Clear requests give your spouse useful information; they do not make the care less meaningful. You can ask, listen to the response, and evaluate follow-through. Repeated dismissal after clear requests is important information and should not be explained away as your failure to communicate.

> *“He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him”* (Proverbs 18:13).

Also see

> “A man takes joy in a fitting reply— and how good is a timely word!” (Proverbs 15:23).

> “Pleasant words are a honeycomb, sweet to the soul and healing to the bones” (Proverbs 16:24).

> “Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself, who is the head” (Ephesians 4:15).

> “My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger” (James 1:19).

Common self-statements

- I should not have to ask.
- If I tell them, it will not count.
- They know exactly what I need and are choosing to ignore it.
- A loving spouse would notice every hint.
- Asking makes me needy.
- If they guess wrong, they do not care.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming your spouse already knows what you have not explained.
- Emotional reasoning: Treating the pain of being missed as proof that you are unloved.
- Hidden rules: Measuring love against an expectation you have not shared.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing requested care is worthless compared with spontaneous care.

Challenging questions

- Did I make a direct request, or hope that a hint would be enough?
- Could my spouse understand the situation differently?

- Would I expect myself to know every unspoken need my spouse has?
- Can love motivate a response after an honest conversation?
- What specific action would help, and when would it be useful?
- What happens when I ask clearly and respectfully, and is that response part of a repeated pattern?

Truth summary

> Being loved does not mean being understood without words. I can name my feelings and ask for a specific action. A caring response after I ask still counts. I can listen to my spouse's needs too, while taking repeated dismissal of my own needs seriously.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Communication
- Love, For Others

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Speak O Lord — Keith and Kristyn Getty
Receive God's Word with humility and allow truth to reshape thought and action.

Jesus — Chris Tomlin
Jesus is present in suffering and is greater than the circumstances we face.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
This classic hymn invites direct, honest prayer with the Savior who carries our burdens.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did I ask directly or only hint?
- ☐ Could my spouse understand this differently?
- ☐ Can either of us read the other's mind?
- ☐ Can requested care still be sincere?
- ☐ What specific action would help me?
- ☐ How does my spouse respond when I ask clearly?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Asking clearly gives love a practical direction.
- ☐ My spouse may care and still misunderstand me.
- ☐ Care offered after a request can be sincere.
- ☐ I can replace a hint with one doable request.
- ☐ My needs matter, and so does my spouse's perspective.
- ☐ I can assess the response without guessing the motive.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Proverbs 18:13
  "He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:23
  "A man takes joy in a fitting reply— and how good is a timely word!"
- ☐ Proverbs 16:24
  "Pleasant words are a honeycomb, sweet to the soul and healing to the bones."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Request-and-response journal: Write the need, your exact request, your prediction, and the response. Separate what your spouse said or did from what you inferred.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Turn one hint into a clear request. Try: "I feel disconnected. Would you sit with me for ten minutes after dinner?" Choose your own words and a suitable time.
- [ ] Check understanding. Ask your spouse to tell you what they understood, then clarify kindly rather than testing them.
- [ ] Invite a request in return. Ask, "What is one thing that would help you this week?" Listen before explaining or defending.
- [ ] Compare prediction with outcome. Rate "If I ask, the care does not count" before and after the conversation. Note evidence without forcing a positive conclusion.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One clear request or listening step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, help me speak the truth with love and listen with patience. Give me courage to name my needs plainly and humility to understand my spouse's needs. Help us turn care into clear, respectful action. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.